

By Sandeep Unnithan

Anurag Kashyap wants to be left alone. For over a week now, the 36-year-old writer-director has been locked away in his Versova flat in suburban Mumbai where he lives with girlfriend Kalki Koechlin. "I have disappeared," says Kashyap in his trademark drawl, "till I finish writing three films." He has tossed away his mobile phone so that he can concentrate on writing in Garbo-esque solitude. For good reason. Ever since *Dev.D*, Kashyap's souped-up contemporarised retelling of the Sarat Chandra Chatterjee classic, his phone has been ringing off the table. The text messages never stop. 'At last'...says one from his former mentor Ram Gopal Varma... 'A film from the groin.' For an industry that has thrived on films made from the heart, think Yash Chopra's mustard fields, *Dev.D*'s unabashed, lusty, below-the-belt sexuality has grossed a handsome Rs 20 crore and still counting, more than the combined budgets of all of Kashyap's six films. Its songs like *Emosanal atyachar* have propelled it into urban pop culture. And though his long-delayed budget *Gulaal*, grounded in the college politics of a small Rajasthan town, hasn't exactly set the box-office afire, it is slowly picking up by word of mouth. Kashyap has now acquired the first trappings of the industry—an efficient secretary who schedules his appointments. And after a decade of bouncing about in autorickshaws on Mumbai's moonscapes, he is finally thinking of buying a car. Kashyap counts Danny Boyle as a friend and Shekhar Kapur who watched both *Dev.D* and *Gulaal* back to back calls him 'one of the most compelling directors in India'.

He has also recently started doing something he's uncomfortable doing: signing autographs. Not bad for an under-the-stairs industry hand who for years after scripting Varma's underworld superhit *Satya* in 1998 struggled to get his foot into the directorial door. When Kashyap finally got a break, he had to deal with the jinxed tag. First was his labour of love, the noirish *Paanch*, the story of five wannabe rocksters made six years ago. The film ran afoul of the censors (who let *Dev.D* breeze through) and is yet to be released though it is already a cult hit in the limited circles where it was screened. It took his

The Dark KNIGHT

BHASKAR PAUL